

LAMENTATIONS

THE LAMENTATIONS OF JEREMIAS.

PREFACE.

In these Jeremias laments in a most pathetic manner the miseries of his people, and the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple, in Hebrew verses, beginning with different letters according to the order of the Hebrew alphabet.

Ch. --- In the first chapter the order is exactly observed, but in the three next the comes before ain, either for some mystery to us unknown, or by the derangement of transcribers, who perhaps thought that those verses were better connected, as they seem to be, (C.) though this is not very clear. H. --- In such pieces the sentiments of a pensive heart are poured out without much connection. W. --- The Greeks style this word threnoi, and Heb. kinoth, or lamentations. H. --- S. Jerom, (2 Par. xxxv. 25.) thinks it was the first composition of Jeremias, and sung at the death of Josias. W. S. Jer. in Zac. xii.

11. --- The eulogy of the king seems to belong to him rather than to Sedecias.

C. iv. 20. C. --- Yet it might afterwards be applied to the latter, (H.) and to the ruin of Jerusalem. Eccli. xlix. 8. S. Jer. Pref.

Theod. &c. --- The city is represented standing, and sometimes in ruins. Chap.

v. seems to have been written after the rest. v. 4, 18. C. --- It is not acrostic like them. The prophet alludes to the wretched condition of the Jews, after the murder of their Messiah; and hence the Church makes use of the lamentations on the anniversary of our Saviour's passion, inviting all sinners, both Jews and Gentiles, to repent: "Jerusalem, Jerusalem, be converted to the Lord thy God." W. --- Many passages are applicable to a soul fallen into sin, as the commentary under the name of S. Jerom, (H.) compiled by Rabanus, (Du Pin) shews. H.

LAMENTATIONS 1

CHAPTER I.

And, &c. This preface was not written by Jeremias, but added by the seventy interpreters, to give the reader to understand upon what occasion the Lamentations were published. Ch. --- The author is not known, (W.) and few assert with Gretser that it is canonical; as it is only a title, (C.) like those prefixed to the Psalms. H. --- It is not found in Heb. Chal. Syr. or S. Jerom. C.

Ver. 1. City. David had conquered many. Jerusalem was long considered as the finest city in those parts. --- Tributary. It had been so to the Assyrians, Egyptians, and Chaldees. 4 K. xxiv. 1.

From this and similar passages, it would seem that the city was still existing: yet in others it appears to have been demolished. Here then the prophet declares what it had been: (C.) unless he wrote part after the death of Josias.

H. --- The beholders are astonished at the change and misery of the city. W.

Ver. 2. Night; privately, or without ceasing. --- Friends, who had made a league with Sedecias.

C. xxvii. 3. and xlviii. 26.

Ver. 3. Rest. Many returning to join Godolias. C. xl. 7. C. --- The Jews who beheld their brethren led away to Babylon, retired into Egypt, but were in misery. W.

Ver. 4. Feast, thrice-a-year. This was the most charming sight, when all the nation met to adore God, and to renew their friendship with one another. C.

Ver. 5. Lords. Lit. "at the head," (H.) which Moses had threatened. Deut. xxvi. 1.

and 43. C. ---

This would be most cutting. W.

Ver. 6. Beauty; princes' palaces, but particularly the temple. v. 10. C. --- Rams, fleeing from place to place to seek relief. W.

Ver. 7. Of all. She compares her past happiness with her present chastisement.

--- Sabbaths, or days of rest. The pagans derided them as so much lost time.

Ignava et partem vitæ non attigit ullam. Juv. v. Seneca ap. S. Aug. de Civ. Dei.

vi. 11. --- If none of their legislators thought of such an institution, it was because they had not the spirit of Moses: their feasts were dissolute. C.

Ver. 8. Unstable. Heb. also, "removed," (H.) like a woman unclean. C. - -- Such were excluded from places of prayer, and were not allowed to touch a sacred book, or to pronounce God's name.

Their husbands could not look at their face, nor give them any thing, but laid it down for them to take. Buxtorf. Syn. 31. --- No condition could be more distressing. C.

Ver. 9. End in her prosperity, to avert this misfortune. H. --- Idolatry is a spiritual adultery, (W.) and one of the worst species of filth. H.

Ver. 10. Church. Deut. xxxiii. 1. Ezech. xliv. 9. The Chaldees disregarded the ordinance.

Ver. 11-12. O. Heb. of the Masor. "It is." C. --- Prot. "Is it nothing to you, all?"

&c. H. --- But the Vulg. is much clearer, and approved by many Protestants, *lu* being often used as an exclamation. Gen. xvii. 18. C. ---

Vintage. He has plundered all. v. 22. H. --- The king took a great deal, and his general the rest. 4

Kin. xxiv. and xxv. W.

Ver. 13. Bones: fortresses. Theod. --- I am like one in a burning fever. Ezec.

xxiv. 4. C. ---

Chastised. Lit. "instructed." This is the good effect of affliction. H.

Ver. 14. Watched. This metaphor is not too harsh. C. xxxi. 28. The Masorets prefer, (C.) "is bound by his hand." Prot. But miskad is explained (H.) by the Sept. &c. in the sense of the Vulg.

God lays the yoke on my neck suddenly. My iniquities are like bands, and Nabuchodonosor has power over me.

Ver. 15. Mighty. Heb. "magnificent" princes, (Lu. xxii. 25.) or warriors. --- Time of vengeance.

All in animated. Heb. also, "a troop" of Chaldees. C. ii. 22. --- Juda. God, as the first cause, punishes the Jews by war.

Ver. 17. Then. They surround the city, to starve the inhabitants. v. 8.

Ver. 19. Me. Egypt attempted to relieve Juda, to no purpose. v. 2. C. --- It could not, or at least did not, prove of any service to the Jews. C. ii. 18. W.

Ver. 20. Alike, by famine, &c. C. W. --- Ubique pavor et plurima mortis imago.

Æn. ii.

Ver. 21. Done it. They conclude that I am cast off for ever. But when I shall be comforted, their turn will come; (C.) or rather they will feel the scourge soon after me. --- Consolation. Heb.

"which thou hast appointed." H. C. xlviii. 26. &c. Ezech. xxv. &c.

Ver. 22. Let. He prays not for their ruin, but predicts it; and wishes rather that they would be converted. C.

LAMENTATIONS 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Obscurity. He continues to bewail the misery of Jerusalem. --- Heaven, the highest glory.

Is. xiv. 12. --- Stool; the temple, and the land. The ark fell not into the hands of the enemy. C. ---

The punishment which the Lord permits, is justly ascribed to Him. W.

Ver. 2. Unclean, or treated it as such. C. --- Sept. "he hath accounted profane the kings." H. ---

Joakim, Jechonias, Sedecias, and the royal family, were exposed to the greatest ignominy and sufferings. C.

Ver. 3. Horn: beauty and power, (H.) the two kingdoms, the fortresses, (C.) and all their strength, denoted by horns. W. --- Hand; refusing us protection, and aiding the Chaldees.

Ver. 5. Women, suffering them to be abused. C. v. 11. 13.

Ver. 6. Tent: the temple, with the same indifference as if it had been a hut, built to guard the fruit of a garden. Is. v. 5. Ps. lxxix. 13. --- Sabbaths. The Jews rested, but could offer no sacrifices in captivity. --- Priest. Saraïas was slain, and Sedecias imprisoned, &c. C. lii. 10. C.

Ver. 7. Cursed, or suffered it to be polluted, (W.) as he looked on it with horror, after it had been profaned by Achaz, &c. --- Towers. Sept. "palaces;" bareon. ---

Feast. What a contrast! The temple used to resound with songs of praise and music: the Chaldees fill it with insolent shouts of victory.

Ver. 8. Line, to level it with the ground, (Is. xxxiv. 11. C.) or to treat it with just severity. Theod.

--- Bulwark. Lit. "the first wall," (H.) or ditch, lined with palisades. Alexander ordered the towers to be levelled, and the horses' manes to be cut, when Hephæstion died, to denote the general sorrow.

Ver. 9. Among, as slaves, or in prison. --- Law has been neglected; and now it cannot be observed, as to the ceremonial part. There are no public instructions. --- No vision. When Jeremias was consulted, he had to pray for ten days. C. xlii. 7.

Ver. 10. Ancients, even magistrates. C. --- Canitiem multo deformat pulvere.

Æn. x.

Ver. 11. Earth, by an overflowing of the bile, occasioned by grief. Job xvi. 14. C.

Ver. 13. Sea. This is an hyperbole, to express the greatness of sorrow, as the sea surpasses all other waters. W.

Ver. 14. Revelations. Heb. Masoth, "burdens" for the enemy. This sentence ought to come before and they, &c. as it is in the Vulg. H.

Ver. 16. Mouth, with scorn. Is. lvii. 4. Ps. xxxiv. 21.

Ver. 17. Old, by Moses, (Deut. xxviii. 15. 49. Lev. xxvi. 14.) Micheas, (C. xxvi.

18.) Holda, &c.

C.

Ver. 18. Upon. Heb. and Sept. "O wall," &c. v. 8. H.

Ver. 19. Watches. Jerusalem is here represented in the midst of danger and misery. C.

Ver. 20. Dealt. Lit. "gathered grapes." C. i. 12. H. --- Long; quite small. Ps.

xxxviii. 9. This has been denounced, C. xix. 9. Deut. xxviii. 53. C. It took place at Samaria, and in the last siege of Jerusalem, (Jos. Bel. vii. and viii. W.) as well as at this time. H.

Ver. 21. Killed. Lit. "stricken" (H.) with unusual severity. W.

Ver. 22. About. The troops of the enemy resemble those multitudes, which come from all parts to Jerusalem. Many kings could not raise such an army. C.

LAMENTATIONS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. Man. Jeremias had a share in the common misery, (W.) and bewails his own condition, as a figure of Christ. Ps. lxxxvii. 16. Is. liii. 3. C. --- His disciples must expect to suffer. H.

Ver. 2. Led, or driven me with the rod. H. --- God employs two. Zac. xi. 7. That of rigour was reserved for this prophet; (C. xxxviii.) none of them suffered more.

Ver. 4. Old and wrinkled, the effect of misery.

Ver. 5. Gall. Sept. "head." Chal. "he hath seized the chief." Job xvi. 13. He speaks in the name of the besieged, who had been threatened with this punishment. v. 19. C. viii. 14. C. --- And labour. Nabuzardan ransacked the city worse than his master, (W.) if the latter was at all present.

H.

Ver. 6. Ever indeed. Eccle. xii. 5. and Ps. xlviii. 12. Jeremias (xxxviii. 6.) was in imminent danger.

Ver. 8. Prayer. God would not allow him to pray for the people. C. vii. 16.

Ver. 9. Stones. There is no passage. Job xix. 8.

Ver. 10. Places. This may refer to the prophet or to the people.

Ver. 12. Arrows. Such places were common where shooting was practised. 1

Kin. xx. 36. Job xvi. 11.

Ver. 14. Song. True prophets were derided on account of impostors, and because of their declarations were unpleasant, &c. C. xvii. 15. Ezech. xii. 22.

Ver. 15. Wormwood, or a bitter poisonous herb. C. ix. 26. Deut. xxix. 18.

Ver. 16. One. Heb. "against a stone." My bread is full of them. Ps. ci. 10. C. ---

He describes his afflictions, as if his teeth had been broken. W.

Ver. 18. End. Heb. "strength." Sept. "victory." C.

Ver. 21. Hope. The remembrance fills him with grief and hope. C. xx. 12. H.

Ver. 23. New. Novi should be novæ, to agree with miserationes. C. --- Chal.

"new miracles"

occur daily. H. --- God's mercies are ever fresh. W.

**Ver. 27. Yoke. Afflictions endured for justice sake ensure a blessing. H. -
-- All may derive great benefit from suffering.**

Ver. 28. Himself, with perfect resignation.

Ver. 29. Hope. He does not doubt, but confides with great humility.

**Ver. 30. Him. We cannot verify this of the prophet as we can of Christ,
(Mat.**

xxvi. 62. C.) to whom this particularly refers. W.

**Ver. 33. Men. He punishes with regret. Ezech. xviii. 23. Our crimes force
him to chastise. v. 36.**

C. --- Yet he seeks our advantage. W.

**Ver. 37. Commanded. Heb. "said: It cometh to pass," as if by chance.
There have always been Epicureans. Ezech. viii. 12. Ps. xciii. 7. C. ---
Those who deny Providence speak. v. 30. W.**

**Ver. 39. Sins? If all happened by inevitable necessity, or according to
the laws of Providence, why should any one complain?**

**Ver. 41. Up. This posture "is the testimony of a soul naturally
Christian." Tert.**

Apol. --- Our heart must accompany our hands. 1 Tim. ii. 8. C.

Ver. 42. Inexorable. Heb. and Sept. "Thou hast not shewn pity." H.

Ver. 43. Covered thyself, as if not to see our distress.

**Ver. 44. Cloud. Is. lix. 2. Eccli. xxxv. 21. These expressions are
admirable.**

**Ver. 47. Prophecy. Many would read, vastatio. Heb. "ruin." Sept.
"taking away."**

C. --- Prot.

"Fear and a snare is come upon us, desolation and destruction." The prophets were continually in danger. H. --- The preaching of false prophets has brought these evils upon the people. W.

Ver. 51. Wasted. Lit. "robbed." H. --- I have felt more for my people than they have themselves.

Moral writers often product this text, to shew the dangers of an unguarded glance (C.) at women.

Ver. 53. Over me, as if I were buried. H. --- Jeremias was in prison (C. xxxviii. 6.) when he prayed. v. 54. C. xx. 7. C.

Ver. 59. Judge what they have judged unjustly. W.

Ver. 62. Lips; or language (Gen. xi. 1.) thou knowest. v. 60.

Ver. 63. Up, all their conduct. --- Song. v. 14.

**Ver. 65. Buckler, to cover all the body. They shall be surrounded with misery, (Ps. cviii. 29.) while God will protect his servants. Ps. v. 13. C. --
- Let sorrow pierce their heart, as thy enemies are treated. W.**

LAMENTATIONS 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Colour. Heb. "gold." Sept. "silver;" (H.) denoting the patriarchs, (Theod.) chiefs, (Vatab.) or ornaments of the temple. C. --- It had formerly glittered with gold; now there was nothing but smoke and ruins. W.

Ver. 2. Best. Heb. "gold of Phaz," in Colchis. Gen. ii. 11. C. --- In Solomon's reign, they powdered their hair with gold dust. Jos. Ant. viii. 7. --- Vessels. Is.

xxx. 14.

Ver. 3. Sea-monsters. Lit. Lamia. Heb. Tannim. H. --- The lamia has a face like a woman, and a body like beasts; and is cruel, yet feeds its young. W. --- The fabulous lamia is supposed to destroy all children, (Diod. Sic. xx. Ovid. Fast.

vi.) and cannot be meant. But the sea dog, though most cruel will not neglect its young ones. C. --- Ostrich. Heb. henim, (H.) "swans." Is.

xiii. 21. Job xxix. 14. The ostrich is said to break some of its eggs. Elian iv. 37.)

-- Swans do the like, and devour their young; for which reason they are hated by the Indians. Elian xiv. 3. ---

Sept. "their young (drajohs) have suckled the daughters of my people, so that they can find no remedy, like," &c. H. --- Though the ostrich has wings it never flies, but dwells in desert places.

Such is the condition of the Israelites. Theodoret. --- The ostrich forsakes its eggs. W. --- All are solicitous for themselves.

Ver. 5. Scarlet. Lit. "yellow;" croceis. H. --- Heb. means purple. Those who have been educated in the most delicate manner, are forced to feed on the most disgusting things. 4 K. vi.

25. and xviii. 27. Deut. xxviii. 54.

Ver. 6. In her. Sodom was destroyed by God. Her temporal misery was short. H.

--- Jerusalem was exposed to greater afflictions (C.) here, (H.) and her ingratitude and abominations were greater. Ezec. xvi. 46.

Ver. 7. Old ivory. Whiteness shews its age. Pliny iii. 8. --- As it grows old it turns yellow, and loses much of its value. But the ancients had the art of dyeing it scarlet. Æneid xii. Iliad iv.

Ovid ii. Am. v. C. --- Heb. poninim may signify (H.) "pearls," the shells of which are stained with a delicate red; though the epithet ruddy may

mean "shining,"

in which sense *purpureus* is used.

Hor. iv. Od. 1. --- The complexion of the Nazarites was fair, with a mixture of red. Cant. v. 10.

They were probably clothed in white, and were highly respected. 1 Mac. ii. 49.

Amos ii. 11.

Num. vi. 18. C.

Ver. 8. Coals. Heb. "blackness." Sept. "soot." H. --- The people were naturally brown. Fasting and distress cause them to turn black. C. v. 10. Joel ii. 6. C. ---

They were so changed, that old acquaintances knew not one another. W.

Ver. 9. For. Lit. "by the barrenness of the earth." H. --- Such a death was, no doubt, more painful than to perish quickly by the sword. C.

Ver. 10. Pitful. So their nature dictates. W. --- But hunger made them the reverse. Some think they slew their children, to prevent them being exposed to more cruel torments, (C.) as the people of Colchis do their sick. Chardin. ---

Sodden: boiled or roasted; coxerunt. v. 5. Deut. xxviii. 55.

At the last siege of Jerusalem, this barbarity was manifested. C. Jos. Bel. vii. 8.

Gr. 21. See C.

ii. 20. --- Daughter. So cities are styled. W.

Ver. 12. Believed. God had so often protected this city against Sennacherib, Holofernes, &c. H.

--- It had been also so strongly fortified. 2 K. v. 6. C.

Ver. 13. Priests. They too generally favoured H. the false prophets. C. ii. 26. &c.

They were judges, and condemned the innocent: or exposed (C.) the citizens to destruction, by not warning them to amend, (H.) and to submit to the Chaldees. C. --- Impostors are called prophets, as they have the same outward appearance. W.

Ver. 14. They. Sept. "Her guards have tottered in," &c. --- When. Prot. "so that men could not touch their garments," as they were defiled. H. -- These hypocrites were afraid of touching blood, as they observed external ceremonies, while they disregarded the spirit of religion.

Ver. 15. Depart. They were not ashamed to speak thus to others, or the citizens address the priests contaminated with blood. Even the Chaldees looked upon the Jews with abhorrence, as an abandoned people. --- For they. Heb. "but they understood not, and wandered about. They, (C.) the Gentiles, said. " H.

Ver. 16. They, the Jews; or rather the prophet thus describes the Chaldees. C.

v. 12. Deut. xxviii.

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Ver. 17. Save. The Egyptians attempted it in vain. C. xxxiv. 8. and xxxvii. 10.

Ver. 18. Streets. There were enemies within as well as without. C.

Ver. 20. Christ, &c. According to the letter, is spoken of their king, who is called the Christ; that is, the anointed of the Lord. But is also relates

in the spiritual sense to Christ our Lord, suffering for our sins. Ch. Is. liii. 5. S. Aug. de Civ.

Dei. xviii. 33. --- It literally speaks of Josias, or of Sedecias. W. --- Josias was slain by the Egyptians. S. Jer. in Zac. xii. --- But Sedecias seems chiefly to be meant. The people were much attached to him, though he was wicked; and they expected that he would have rescued them from the power of the Chaldees, as his league with the neighbouring Gentiles (C.) seemed to insure, (H.) if they had proved faithful. C. --- But all was useless against the Lord. H.

Ver. 21. Rejoice. Edom had manifested her joy at the misfortunes of Juda. The prophet hints at this with a cutting irony. Ps. cxxxvi. 7. Abd. 11. --- Come, as at a feast. Edom was visited five years after the Jews. C. xlix. 7. --- Naked. Sept.

"and shalt pour it out," (H.) or vomit. C. Grot.

Ver. 22. Accomplished, and sufficiently punished by exile. C. l. 20. Is. xl. 2. ---

Discovered.

Gen. xliv. 16. and 3 K. xvii. 18. C. --- In vain wouldst thou hide them. H.

LAMENTATIONS 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 1. The prayer, &c. This title is not in Heb. Sept. &c. Theodoret has passed over the chapter, as if he doubted of its authenticity. It does not follow the order of Heb. letters like the preceding, and seems to be a form of prayer for those who retired into Egypt. C. --- Jeremias foresees what would happen, and prays as the people would do. W.

Ver. 2. Aliens. The Idumeans seized and kept possession of the southern parts.

Ver. 3. Father. Many had none surviving, and all had lost their king. W.

Ver. 4. Water. Even this was not given for nothing.

Ver. 6. Hand; engaged to serve Egyptians, Babylonians, (C.) or other nations, to procure sustenance. W.

Ver. 7. Iniquities. This was the usual complaint of the Jews, (C. xxxi. 29.) as if they had committed no offence themselves. If any virtuous people were involved in common ruin, they bore it with resignation, and acknowledged that they had deserved it. 1 Esd. ix. 6. and 2 Esd. i. 6.

Est. xiv. 6. Dan. iii. 29.

Ver. 8. Servants. One had command over another. Mat. xxiv. 45. The Chaldees were like slaves, and the race of Cham was condemned to servitude. Gen. ix.

26. C. --- The Jews had formerly dominion over Edom, &c. who now treated them so cruelly. M. Lyran.

Ver. 9. Sword. Any one might kill us.

Ver. 11. Oppressed. Heb. "afflicted." Brutal insolence prevailed. C.

Ver. 12. Hand. Thus Leonidas was treated, after his head was cut off, by Xerxes. Herod. vii.

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Ver. 13. Indecently, like the Sodomites. Heb. "they made the young men grind"

at the mill, in their prison, (H.) as Samson (Judg. xvi. 21.) and Sedecias (according to the Sept. C. lii. 11.) were forced to do. To grind is often used in a bad sense; but it is not necessary to adopt it here. C.

Amama. --- The Chaldees treated their captives without pity or shame. H. ---

Wood; burdens, or stumbling-blocks, unless they were crucified; or, "roasted,"

if we admit a small alteration in the Heb. C. iv. 10. C. --- They were forced to grind naked, and were beaten with staves. W.

Ver. 14. Gates, where sentence was usually passed. H. --- The Jews had judges at Babylon, (Dan. xiii. 5.) but not at first, nor everywhere.

Ver. 16. Crown, used at feasts; (C.) or, we have lost the sovereign power. W.

Ver. 17. Dim, the natural consequence of extreme want. 1 K. xiv. 27.

Ver. 18. Foxes, which were very common. Judg. xv. 4. Thus, Horace says: *Agros atque lares patrios, habitandaque fana*

Apris relinquet et edacibus lupis. Epod. 16.

Ver. 21. Convert. Thy grace must work upon our hearts, (C.) before we can expect redress, (H.) and an end of our banishment. T. Grot. --- Beginning, when our fathers observed the law. S.

Tho. M. See C. xxxi. 18. S. Aug. de Civ. Dei. ii. and iv. W.

Ver. 22. Thou hast. We might read with an interrogation, (H.) in Heb. "Hast thou?" &c. The Jews superstitiously repeat the last verse, for fear of ending the book in an ominous manner, as they do at the end of *Isaias* and *Malachias*.

C. --- Having treated us so severely, stop thy hand.

W. --- But I perceive it will be in vain to beg for redress till the seventy years be expired. M.